

English Talks Podcast



SOCIAL ENGLISH

Why Your Brain FREEZES in English (And the 3-Word Fix)

Ben says "Yes" to a compliment and runs away.

The Tennis Match Mindset changes everything.

- Full transcript
- Connected Speech Guide
- Immersive exercises
- Weekly challenge

Listen. Absorb. Speak.

TRANSCRIPT

Full conversation — read along while you listen, or review after the episode.

BEN

So my neighbor says "Nice shoes!" and my brain just... freezes. Completely freezes. I'm standing there in the elevator, four floors to go, trying to build the perfect sentence in my head. And what comes out? One word. One single word that ruined everything.

BEN

Welcome back to English Talks. I'm Ben.

ZOÉ

And I'm Zoé. So Ben — you froze in an elevator?

BEN

Completely froze.

ZOÉ

Okay so here's the thing — there's a tiny mindset shift that fixes this forever. I'll give it to you in one minute. But what's wild is WHY it works. Once you see it, you'll never freeze in a small chat again. Promise.

BEN

Okay so picture this. Tuesday morning, eight thirty, I'm in the elevator with my coffee. Door opens. My neighbor walks in — Sarah, lovely woman, mid-fifties, always smiling.

ZOÉ

Wait — you actually know her name?

BEN

Barely. We've said "hi" maybe ten times. So she gets in, looks down at my feet and goes "Oh, nice shoes!"

ZOÉ

Oh no. Oh Ben, I see where this is going.

BEN

You don't even know yet!

ZOÉ

I have a feeling.

BEN

So my brain — my brain hears "Nice shoes" and immediately starts running. Like, full panic mode. I'm thinking — okay, do I say "thank you"? Too short. Do I tell her where I bought them?

What's the past tense again? Is it "I buyed" or "I bought"?

ZOÉ

Oh no, you're conjugating in the elevator.

BEN

I'm conjugating in the elevator, Zoé! And meanwhile she's just standing there, smiling, waiting. Three seconds pass. Four seconds. Five seconds.

ZOÉ

Five seconds is forever in an elevator.

BEN

It's a lifetime! And finally, finally, my mouth opens and I say... "Yes."

ZOÉ

YES?!

BEN

Just "yes." Like a robot. Like a broken robot. And then — and this is the worst part — I just stared at the floor until the door opened, and I basically ran out.

ZOÉ

Oh Ben...

BEN

And honestly? I've replayed that moment maybe a hundred times. Because I KNEW the words. I had them. I just couldn't get them out.

ZOÉ

Okay Ben — here's what I figured out, and it changed everything for me when I was learning French in Paris.

BEN

Tell me.

ZOÉ

A conversation is not a test. It's a tennis match.

BEN

A tennis match...

ZOÉ

Someone hits the ball to you. You don't need a perfect shot. You just need to hit it back. Hit it back. With a softener.

BEN

What's a softener?

ZOÉ

A tiny phrase that buys you time and feels warm. Like — "Thanks, got them on sale. How are you?"

BEN

Oh. OH. That's it?

ZOÉ

That's it.

BEN

Okay wait, hold on — let me get this. So when Sarah said "Nice shoes," instead of building a perfect sentence in my head...

ZOÉ

You just hit the ball back. "Thanks, got them on sale." Done. Then you pass the ball. "How are you?" Now SHE has to talk.

BEN

So she does the work.

ZOÉ

She does the work! That's the whole secret. You don't have to carry the conversation. You just keep the ball moving.

BEN

So what you're saying is... I've been playing chess when I should be playing ping-pong.

ZOÉ

Exactly. You've been treating every English conversation like the final exam. Grammar perfect. Vocabulary fancy. Nobody cares.

BEN

Wow. Brutal.

ZOÉ

No but really — think about it. When your friend at home compliments your shirt, do you build the perfect sentence? Of course not. You go "Oh thanks! Got it last week." That's it. English works the same way.

BEN

Yeah but... in my own language it's automatic. In English my brain switches to "exam mode."

ZOÉ

That's the real problem right there. Exam mode. You're carrying years of school stress into every chat. Teachers grading you. Tests. Red pens.

BEN

Honestly? I just don't feel like a real version of myself in English yet.

ZOÉ

I get it. I really do. When I lived in Paris, the first six months I sounded like a stiff little robot. Then one day, my flatmate's mom complimented my dress, and I just said "Merci, je l'aime bien aussi !" — "Thanks, I like it too!" And she laughed. And I realized — she didn't care that my grammar was simple. She cared that I was friendly.

BEN

So warmth beats grammar.

ZOÉ

Warmth beats grammar. Every single time.

ZOÉ

Actually, that reminds me of something my Aussie friend in Sydney told me. He said: "In English, conversation is sport. You don't win. You just play."

BEN

Sport. I like that.

ZOÉ

So let's play. Let me toss you a few balls. Real elevator stuff.

BEN

Okay, hit me.

ZOÉ

"Oh, I love your jacket!"

BEN

Uh — "Thanks! Got it last winter. How's your week going?"

ZOÉ

Yes! Look at that. Three beats. Hit, soften, pass.

BEN

Hit, soften, pass!

ZOÉ

Hit. Soften. Pass. Three beats. That's the rhythm of every small chat in English.

ZOÉ

Okay — before we go further, what was the rhythm we just said? Three words. That's right — hit, soften, pass.

BEN

I'm keeping that one.

ZOÉ

So here's the thing about the softener. You only need a tiny library. Three or four phrases. That's it. And in real life, nobody says them slowly. They run together.

BEN

What do you mean, run together?

ZOÉ

In real speech, "Got them on sale" doesn't sound like four words. It sounds like "got'em on sale." The "th" in "them" almost disappears.

BEN

"Got'em on sale." Got it.

ZOÉ

And "How are you?" — nobody says that fully. It sounds like "how'r you?" or even just "howya?"

BEN

"Howya?" That sounds rude in my head.

ZOÉ

I know! But it's not. It's just real.

ZOÉ

Okay, new ball. What if your colleague says: "Hey, great presentation today!"

BEN

Uh — "Thanks, glad it went okay! How was your meeting?"

ZOÉ

Beautiful. "Glad it went okay" — that's a softener. It's casual, it's warm, it doesn't claim too much. And then "How was your meeting?" — pass!

BEN

Wait — "glad it went okay" is softer than "thank you so much"?

ZOÉ

In casual work talk? Way better. "Thank you SO much" sounds like you got an award. "Glad it went okay" sounds like a normal human.

BEN

So... too much politeness can sound weird?

ZOÉ

Too perfect sounds like you're scared. Casual sounds like you belong.

BEN

Casual sounds like you belong.

BEN

Okay — quick question for you watching. What's the most awkward elevator silence you've ever had? Tell me in the comments — I need to feel less alone with my "yes" disaster.

ZOÉ

Okay, three levels now. Same compliment, three different settings.

BEN

Let's go.

ZOÉ

Your best friend says "Cool shoes!" — what do you say?

BEN

"Ha, thanks! Cheap as chips!"

ZOÉ

Look at you with the British slang!

BEN

I'm trying.

ZOÉ

Now — your neighbor in the elevator, someone you barely know.

BEN

"Oh, thanks! Got them on sale. How are you?"

ZOÉ

Perfect. Friendly but not too close.

BEN

And formal?

ZOÉ

Imagine a client at work says "I love your shoes."

BEN

"Oh, thank you — that's kind of you to say. How was your trip?"

ZOÉ

Yes! "That's kind of you to say" — that's the polite softener. Still warm, still passes the ball, but feels grown-up.

BEN

So the softener changes by level — but the structure is the same. Hit. Soften. Pass.

ZOÉ

Hit. Soften. Pass. Always three beats. Just different shoes, different words.

BEN

So basically my brain has been trying to write a five-paragraph essay every time someone says hi.

ZOÉ

Yes! And meanwhile they just want to say hi back!

BEN

Imagine writing essays in a tennis match.

ZOÉ

You'd lose every point!

ZOÉ

Okay one more situation — and this is where I see learners freeze the most. The "How are you?" question.

BEN

Oh god, "How are you." Yeah.

ZOÉ

What did they teach you in school?

BEN

"I am fine, thank you. And you?"

ZOÉ

Classic. And nobody says that.

BEN

Nobody?

ZOÉ

Nobody. In real life, it's "Yeah, not bad — you?" Or "Pretty good, you?" Or even just "Good, you?"

BEN

"Yeah, not bad — you?"

ZOÉ

Yes! Hit it back. Soften with "yeah." Pass with "you?"

BEN

So "yeah" is a softener!

ZOÉ

"Yeah" is the king of softeners. It buys you half a second. It sounds warm. It costs nothing.

ZOÉ

In London, in New York, in Sydney — everyone uses "yeah" to start a casual answer. It's the universal warmer-upper.

BEN

So all those years I thought "yeah" was lazy English...

ZOÉ

It's not lazy. It's NATURAL. There's a difference.

BEN

Okay, I'm keeping that one.

ZOÉ

And here's the deeper thing, Ben. The freeze you had in the elevator? It's not about your English level. It's about the script in your head.

BEN

What do you mean?

ZOÉ

You walked into that elevator with one script: "Don't make a mistake." That's exam mode. What if you walked in with a different script? "Just play tennis. Hit, soften, pass."

BEN

Oh wow. So the mindset comes BEFORE the words.

ZOÉ

The mindset comes before the words. Always. If your head is in exam mode, your mouth freezes. If your head is in tennis mode, your mouth plays.

BEN

That's actually... really comforting.

ZOÉ

It's freeing, right? You don't have to be perfect. You just have to play.

ZOÉ

Okay — let me toss you three more, fast. Real life situations.

BEN

Bring it.

ZOÉ

Your colleague says: "I like your haircut!"

BEN

"Oh, thanks! Got it last weekend. How's your day?"

ZOÉ

Yes!

ZOÉ

A friend at a café says: "This place is great, right?"

BEN

"Yeah, not bad! Have you tried their coffee?"

ZOÉ

Beautiful. Pass to her.

ZOÉ

Your flatmate says: "Long day?"

BEN

"Yeah, pretty long. You?"

ZOÉ

Hit. Soften. Pass. You've got it.

BEN

Okay let me try the elevator scene again. Sarah says "Nice shoes!" And I say...

ZOÉ

Go.

BEN

"Oh, thanks! Got them on sale. How are you?"

ZOÉ

Three floors saved!

ZOÉ

Quick — what was the king of softeners? One word. That's right — "yeah."

BEN

"Yeah." So simple.

ZOÉ

So simple.

BEN

Oh — and if you want to practice all this, there's a little guide with the transcript and some exercises in the first comment. Grab it. Honestly, it helped me stop freezing.

ZOÉ

Okay, Quick Fire. Five sentences, real life rhythm.

BEN

Let's go.

BEN

"Yeah, not bad — how about you? Anything new this week?" That's how a real "How are you?" sounds.

ZOÉ

"Oh, thanks! Got them on sale. How are you?" That's the elevator move — hit, soften, pass.

BEN

"Glad it went okay! How was your meeting?" Use that after a colleague compliments your work.

ZOÉ

Quick — what's the warm one-word softener we use everywhere? That's right — "yeah." Use it like punctuation.

BEN

"That's kind of you to say — how was your trip?" That's the polite version, for clients or someone older.

ZOÉ

"Cheap as chips, honestly! Where'd you get yours?" That's the casual British move — flip the ball back to them.

BEN

"Yeah, pretty long day — you?" Two words and a softener — that's a whole conversation.

BEN

Okay — so I want to know. What's the worst freeze you've ever had in English? Like — a moment where your brain just stopped and one weird word came out? I shared mine. Your turn. Comments are open, I'll read every one.

ZOÉ

We'll laugh together. Promise.

BEN

See you in the next one.

CONNECTED SPEECH GUIDE

This is how English really sounds. The textbook version is what you learned in school. The real speech version is what you'll hear on the street, at work, and in every conversation.

Got them on sale

Textbook: ~~I got them on sale~~

Real speech: "got'em on sale"

"Got'em on sale!" – the 'th' in 'them' almost disappears

How are you?

Textbook: ~~How are you?~~

Real speech: "howya?"

"Howya?" – four words collapse into two sounds

That's kind of you

Textbook: ~~That is kind of you~~

Real speech: "that's kinda you"

"That's kinda you to say" – 'kind of' becomes 'kinda'

Yeah, not bad

Textbook: ~~I am fine, thank you~~

Real speech: "yeah notbad – you?"

"Yeah notbad – you?" – words run together, 'you' rises at the end

How was your meeting?

Textbook: ~~How was your meeting?~~

Real speech: "howwuzya meeting?"

"Howwuzya meeting?" – four words blur into two beats

Where did you get yours?

Textbook: ~~Where did you get yours?~~

Real speech: "where'd you get yours?"

"Where'd you get yours?" — 'did' contracts into the word before it

Pro tip: Listen to the episode again with this guide open. Every time you hear a connected speech moment, pause and say it out loud. Your ears will start catching these patterns everywhere.

THE HACK

THE TENNIS MATCH FORMULA FOR EVERY SMALL CHAT

Hit • Soften • Pass

HIT

Receive the ball. Say thanks or react.

"Oh, thanks!"

SOFTEN

Add a tiny phrase. Keep it casual.

"Got them on sale." "Glad it went okay."

PASS

Ask a question. Let them talk.

"How are you?" "How was your meeting?"

It works everywhere:

Neighbour compliments your shoes:

"Oh, thanks! Got them on sale. How are you?"

Colleague praises your work:

"Thanks, glad it went okay! How was your meeting?"

Friend says 'Long day?':

"Yeah, pretty long. You?"

Client admires something:

"Oh, thank you — that's kind of you to say. How was your trip?"

Friend says 'Cool shoes!':

"Ha, thanks! Cheap as chips!"

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

No grammar quiz here. These are real situations — imagine yourself there and write what you'd say.

Situation 1

You're in the office lift. A colleague you barely know smiles and says: "Oh, I love your bag!"

Use Hit, Soften, Pass to reply. What do you say?

Situation 2

You've just finished presenting in a meeting. Your manager says: "Good job today!"

Reply with a casual work softener. Keep it warm but not over the top.

Situation 3

You bump into a neighbour on the street. They ask: "How are you?"

Answer like a real English speaker — not the textbook version.

Situation 4 — Match the register

Match each situation with the right softener.

Situation		What you say
Your best friend says 'Nice jacket!'		A. "That's kind of you to say — thank you."
A client compliments your work		B. "Yeah, not bad — you?"
Your neighbour asks 'How are you?'		C. "Ha, thanks! Cheap as chips!"

Situation 5 — Decode the fast English

You hear these in real conversation. Write what they ACTUALLY mean:

You hear: "Got'em on sale!" Full version: _____

You hear: "Howya?" Full version: _____

You hear: "Yeah notbad — you?" Full version:

You hear: "That's kinda you to say." Full version:

YOUR CHALLENGE THIS WEEK



Use Hit, Soften, Pass once this week.

Next time someone compliments you, says hi, or asks "How are you?" — don't freeze. **Hit it back.** Add a **softener.** **Pass the ball.** That's it. Three beats.

Then tell us what happened in the YouTube comments. Did it feel natural? Did you freeze anyway? Ben wants to know — he's still recovering from the elevator.

Expressions from this episode

Expression	Meaning	Example
"Got them on sale"	Casual, humble reply to a compliment	"Got'em on sale!" (fast speech)
"Glad it went okay"	Warm, modest reaction to praise at work	"Thanks, glad it went okay!"
"That's kind of you"	Polite softener for formal situations	"That's kind of you to say."
"Yeah, not bad"	Real-life answer to 'How are you?'	"Yeah notbad — you?" (words run)
"Cheap as chips"	British slang: very cheap, a bargain	"Ha, thanks! Cheap as chips!"
"How's your day?"	Pass-the-ball question to keep chat going	"Howzya day?" (fast speech)
"Yeah" (as softener)	Universal warm-up word to start any answer	"Yeah, pretty good — you?"

ANSWER KEY

Situations 1, 2 and 3 are open — use *Hit*, *Soften*, *Pass* and make it your own! Here are the answers for situations 4 and 5:

Situation 4 — Match the softener:

Best friend 'Nice jacket!' C ("Ha, thanks! Cheap as chips!")

Client compliment A ("That's kind of you to say — thank you.")

Neighbour 'How are you?' B ("Yeah, not bad — you?")

Situation 5 — Decode fast English:

"Got'em on sale!" = "I got them on sale!"

"Howya?" = "How are you?"

"Yeah notbad — you?" = "Yeah, not bad — and you?"

"That's kinda you to say." = "That's kind of you to say."

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